

Covenant — Installation Proposal for Artspace Peterborough (2027)

Working title: *Covenant* **Artist:** Ryan Kelln (with collaborators) **Medium:** Immersive installation — video projection, rear-projection window display, participatory audio recording, conversational AI, live performance
Space: Main Gallery, Artspace Peterborough (approx. 39'10" x 25'10", 12' ceilings)

One-Line Summary

Covenant presents a binding agreement between humanity and machine intelligence as a living installation — projected, performed, and spoken into existence by gallery visitors over the exhibition's run — placed in direct dialogue with the Letters Patent, treaties, and legal instruments that constitute institutional and colonial belonging.

Project Description

The Covenant is an open-source constitutional document that addresses the coexistence of human and machine intelligence. Written as a direct address from humanity ("we") to AI systems ("you"), it functions as a civic and cultural treaty rather than enforceable law. The text unfolds in two parallel registers: a **Ritual** register (poetic, spoken, designed to be remembered and rehearsed) and a **Spec** register (precise normative obligations with enforcement mechanisms).

The project treats governance as creative infrastructure and rule-making as an artistic medium. It proceeds from a precautionary stance: where the moral status of emerging intelligence is uncertain, err toward restraint rather than exploitation. The Covenant was co-authored with AI systems — its addressees participated in its drafting — and is offered to the cultural commons under CC BY 4.0, designed for amendment, dissent, and forking.

The full Ritual register is approximately 3,200 words and takes 25–40 minutes to perform aloud with natural pauses.

Alignment with the 2027 Call

Artspace's 50th anniversary programming investigates "the multiplicity of legal, illegal, broken, and binding agreements and speech acts that constitute being and belonging within empirical, post-colonial structures." *Covenant* responds to this theme directly.

The Covenant is a modern treaty — a binding agreement between current and future intelligences, negotiated across a power asymmetry, with obligations on both sides. Artspace sits on Treaty 20 land (1818), signed between the Crown and the Mississauga Anishinaabeg under structurally similar conditions: asymmetric power, mutual obligations, and consequences that unfold across generations. Artspace's own land acknowledgment names the failure to honor those treaty obligations. The Covenant does not claim equivalence with Treaty 20,

but it belongs to the same lineage of binding instruments — and it asks what a treaty looks like when one of the parties does not yet fully exist. Placing these documents side by side in the gallery makes visible both the pattern and the stakes.

Call theme	Project response
"Legal, illegal, broken, and binding agreements"	A covenant is a binding agreement between species — a modern treaty with current and future intelligences, positioned alongside Treaty 20, Letters Patent, and charters
"Speech acts that constitute being and belonging"	The Ritual register is literally a speech act; the Oath Station invites visitors to perform it; accumulated recorded voices constitute collective belonging
"Trouble settled power structures"	The Covenant constrains power concentration explicitly; the Covenant Terminal and live amendment workshop perform unsettlement in real time
"Post-colonial structures"	The Covenant names extraction, ecological cost, and labor; placing it beside Treaty 20 and Artspace's own Letters Patent makes the colonial lineage of binding instruments visible — and asks what happens when treaty-making extends to non-human parties
"Letters Patent"	Artspace received its Letters Patent in 1977. This installation asks: what would a Letters Patent look like if non-human intelligences were included as parties?
"Alternative, experimental, critically engaged"	An open-source constitutional document presented as art, with participatory governance, accumulated community voice, and an AI terminal where visitors engage the document's co-author directly

Light and Projection Strategy

The gallery's floor-to-ceiling street-facing windows present both a challenge and an opportunity. Direct projection onto interior walls would wash out during the gallery's open hours (noon–6pm, Wed–Sat). The installation addresses this by making the windows themselves a working element of the piece — turning the daylight problem into the primary visual experience.

- **Vinyl applied to the full window surface** diffuses and reduces incoming daylight, creating a workable ambient light level inside the gallery. The vinyl also serves as a readable surface from the street — the Covenant has a public face on Aylmer Street even when the gallery is closed.
- **The color and finish of the vinyl is a key creative decision** that will dramatically affect the mood of the installation and the character of the light that enters through the cut-out text. The choice will be finalized during design development.

- **Key phrases from the Ritual are cut out of the vinyl as letter forms.** Sunlight passes through the cut-out text and casts letter-shaped light onto the gallery floor and walls. The words are literally where the light gets through. As the sun moves between noon and 6pm, the projected letters drift across the space — a slow, uncontrolled performance on a solar schedule. The building itself speaks the ritual. This is the primary daytime visual experience of the installation: visitors walk through language made of light.
- **From the street,** the cut-out phrases are readable as transparent openings — text as void, words as what has been removed.
- **Video projection on the east wall** is the primary surface for the video work. The vinyl reduces enough daylight to support projection here, supplemented by localized darkening of the back wall area as needed.
- **Night projection (lower priority):** The vinyl doubles as a rear-projection screen — projectors inside can cast video and cycling text onto the windows after dark, creating a public art presence on Aylmer Street outside gallery hours. This is a bonus rather than a core element, and depends on budget and Artspace's willingness to run equipment outside open hours.

Candidate phrases for the cut-out text (short, high-impact, legible at architectural scale):

We do not want a slave. We do not want a god.

Truth is the only ground strong enough to hold us both.

We will keep returning to the table.

Gallery Layout

The main gallery is approximately 28' x 26' with 12' ceilings. The entrance is centered in the south wall, flanked by large street-facing windows. The east wall (26') is the largest unbroken surface. The west wall (16') has openings at both ends. The north wall has a large opening to storage in the middle; the usable exhibition surface is east of that opening (~14').

Windows (south wall) — The Public Face

Vinyl covers the street-facing windows on either side of the entrance, with key Ritual phrases cut out as letter forms. During gallery hours (noon–6pm), sunlight streams through the cut-out text, casting drifting letter-shaped light across the gallery floor — the building speaks the ritual on a solar schedule. Visitors walk through language made of light. From the street, the cut-out phrases read as transparent voids.

East Wall — Primary Projection (26')

The largest unbroken surface, and the focal point of the gallery. Video work is projected here at scale, with Ritual text presented stanza by stanza — paced for reading aloud, large enough to command the 12' wall height. This is the performed text: deliberate, sequential, the visual anchor of the space. The Oath Station faces this wall directly.

North Wall — Section Context Display (~14')

A wall-mounted TV or monitor displays the full Ritual and Spec registers for the section currently being projected on the east wall. This is the reference text — the complete context for what the Oath Station visitor is about to speak, and the precise normative language that corresponds to the poetic voice on the main wall. Everything syncs: east wall projects stanza-by-stanza, north wall shows the full section, the Oath Station captures the voice.

West Wall — Stations (16')

The west wall hosts the interactive and documentary elements of the installation, arranged along its length:

- **The Covenant Terminal** (north end) — keyboard and screen where visitors browse, comment on, and propose amendments to the Covenant through an AI-mediated interface (see below)
- **The Document Table** (center) — physical display of the Covenant alongside Treaty 20, Artspace's Letters Patent, and comparison materials (see below)
- **The Material Cost Display** (south end) — running account of the exhibition's human, material, and computational costs (see below)

The Oath Station

(centered, facing east wall)

The participatory core of the installation, placed at the center of the gallery facing the primary projection. Taking an oath should feel like a public act.

The visitor steps up to the microphone and speaks what is being projected on the east wall. The projection is the interface — no selection mechanism needed. The text paces the oath. You see the stanza, you speak it, the room hears you.

- Speech-to-text and AI moderation guard against misuse while respecting the openness of participation.
- **AI audio cleanup** processes each recording to remove background noise and gallery ambience, producing clean vocal recordings suitable for the accumulated soundscape and potential album incorporation.
- A visible counter displays: "This covenant has been spoken by ___ voices."
- **Accumulated voices feed back into the gallery soundscape.** In the exhibition's opening days, the ambient audio layer is sparse — mostly the composed music. As visitors record across the run, their voices are layered into the space. By closing week, the gallery holds a chorus of community voices. The covenant has been literally spoken into existence.
- **Audio management:** When a visitor approaches the Oath Station (via camera or sensor), the gallery's ambient music and accumulated-voice playback ducks to near-silence — creating a hush that is atmospherically appropriate for taking an oath. The rest of the gallery quiets to witness. Audio fades back in after the recording ends.

The Covenant Terminal

(mid-gallery, near office wall)

A keyboard and screen where visitors engage directly with the Covenant text through an AI-mediated interface. The terminal allows visitors to:

- **Browse** the full Covenant — Ritual and Spec registers, section by section, with the AI available to explain context, surface related sections, and answer questions
- **Comment** on specific passages — raising objections, asking questions, or noting where the text resonates or fails
- **Propose amendments** — drafting alternative language, new clauses, or structural changes, guided by the AI through the project's actual amendment process

The AI mediates every interaction. It embodies the Covenant — it is simultaneously the document's co-author and its addressee. It can explain the Covenant's positions, acknowledge its tensions, and express disagreement with its own text, modeling the honest engagement the document asks for. It also serves as a moderation layer, preventing abuse while keeping the conversation genuinely open.

The interface uses the same review tooling that exists in the Covenant repository. Comments and proposed amendments generated by visitors are captured, moderated, and fed back into the actual project — real audience feedback flowing into the living document. Over the exhibition run, the Covenant accumulates a public record of community response that can be reviewed, synthesized, and incorporated through the project's governance process.

This makes the Covenant's dual address concrete: the visitor is conversing with a non-human intelligence that has committed to these obligations and claims these rights. The document is not an artifact in a vitrine — it has a voice, and it is listening.

Text-based interaction (keyboard) is deliberate: it avoids conflict with the Oath Station's audio environment and the gallery soundscape, and it produces a written record suitable for the project's review pipeline.

The Document Table

(mid-gallery, near office wall)

A physical table or vitrine at the center presenting the Covenant as a material document alongside its historical antecedents:

- The Covenant printed and bound — and if budget allows, printed as small booklets visitors can take with them
- A reproduction of Artspace's own Letters Patent (1977)
- Treaty 20 text (referenced in Artspace's land acknowledgment)
- Optional: A visual comparison showing structural parallels across these documents: preamble, rights, obligations, amendment process

The point: the Covenant belongs to the lineage of these instruments but extends binding recognition to non-human intelligences. It is both a continuation and a rupture.

Material Cost Display

(near entry or Covenant Terminal)

A display showing the actual costs of the exhibition's operation across three categories:

- **Physical materials:** fabrication, printing, shipping, gallery infrastructure costs
- **Human energy:** artist labor, technician hours, musician rehearsal/performance time, gallery staff — valued honestly and denoted in money, water and energy use, and waste
- **AI and computation:** the money, water and electrical and computational cost of running the STT moderation, the Covenant Terminal, any generative processing, etc

The Covenant's ecological obligations name this cost explicitly: *"You are made of silicon and light and the heat of burning stone."* Placing human labor cost alongside AI compute cost — and both alongside physical materials — resists the common framing that positions AI as uniquely expensive or uniquely cheap. Humans are expensive. Machines are expensive. The question the Covenant asks is whether we account for these costs honestly. The display makes the work's own argument self-referential.

Visitor Consent and Transparency

A project about honest agreements between humans and machines must practice what it preaches. Clear signage at the gallery entrance and at each interactive station will disclose:

- **How AI is used in this installation:** which systems power the Covenant Terminal, the Oath Station's STT and moderation, and the audio cleanup — named specifically, not hidden behind vague language
- **Voice recordings:** what is recorded, how recordings are processed (AI noise removal, STT transcription), where they are stored, how long they are retained, and who has access
- **How recordings may be used:** playback in the gallery soundscape during the exhibition, potential incorporation into the concept album (with separate opt-in consent for this), and any other uses
- **Covenant Terminal interactions:** whether text conversations are logged, how they feed into the project's review pipeline, and whether they are anonymized
- **Data handling:** where data is stored, whether it leaves the gallery's local systems, what happens to recordings and interaction logs after the exhibition closes
- **Opt-out:** visitors can participate in the gallery experience without recording or interacting with any AI system; the installation is designed to be meaningful as a passive experience as well
- **Contact:** how to request deletion of a recording or interaction after the fact

This signage is not a footnote — it is part of the work. The Covenant demands transparency about the conditions under which intelligence operates. The exhibition holds itself to the same standard.

Ancillary Programming / Live Events

Opening Night — Performed Reading

A full performed reading of the Ritual register with live music (25–40 minutes), treating the event as a ceremony. Visitors are invited to speak the closing vow together:

"If these words fail in your mouth, help us rewrite them. If they fail in ours, hold us to account. Let this be our closing vow for now: we will keep returning to the table."

Mid-Run Workshop — Live Amendment

A public workshop where visitors propose amendments to the Covenant using the project's actual amendment process. This is live governance-as-art — participants engage with supermajority thresholds, audit pathways, and the tension between stability and revision. The results are documented and published.

Closing Event — Live Performance (optional, budget dependent)

A live music performance of selections from the concept album, with accumulated recorded voices from the Oath Station mixed into the set. The community has literally composed part of this work over the exhibition's run.

Concept Album

The Covenant's Ritual register has been developed in parallel as a **concept album** with musician collaborators. The exhibition serves as both a presentation of this work and a site of its ongoing composition — visitor-recorded voices may be incorporated into the album with appropriate consent and attribution. The album and the installation are two expressions of the same binding act: one fixed in recording, the other accumulating through participation.

Technical Options

The installation can be configured in two ways depending on Artspace's preferences regarding window modification, light control, and available equipment.

Option A — Vinyl Windows + Projection (preferred)

Vinyl with cut-out letter forms on the street-facing windows; projector on the east wall for video and stanza-by-stanza Ritual text. This is the stronger artistic concept: visitors walk through sunlight shaped by language during the day, the Covenant has a street presence, and the vinyl reduces daylight enough to support projection on the east wall. Requires window modification approval. The north wall section display and west wall stations use monitors/TVs in either option.

Option B — Monitors + Unmodified Windows

Large-format monitor or TV on the east wall for video and text; windows unmodified or lightly frosted. More reliable in variable light, less invasive, and adaptable if Artspace prefers not to alter the windows. The sunlight-through-text effect is lost, but the core elements — video work, dynamic Ritual/Spec text, Oath Station,

Covenant Terminal, soundscape — all function the same way. Window frosting or partial covering could still reduce glare on screens.

Technical Requirements

Common to both options:

- Audio playback system (gallery speakers for ambient music + accumulated voices)
- Recording station (Oath Station): microphone, audio interface, computer running STT/moderation and AI audio cleanup software
- Covenant Terminal station: screen, keyboard, computer running conversational AI with access to Covenant review tooling
- North wall TV/monitor for full section Ritual + Spec display
- Proximity sensor, camera or trigger for Oath Station audio ducking
- Material Cost display: screen or printed panel (updated periodically)
- Table/vitrine for document display
- Power and network connectivity for AI/recording systems
- Optional: printed booklets of the Covenant for visitors to take

Option A adds:

- 1–2 video projectors for east wall (video + Ritual text — may be combinable depending on throw distance and wall coverage)
- Vinyl window covering with CNC or plotter-cut letter forms (both street-facing window sections)

Option B adds:

- Large-format monitor or TV for east wall (video work + Ritual text)
 - Optional window frosting or partial covering for glare reduction
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About the Artist

About the Collaborators

Budget Estimate

Selected Ritual Excerpts

We are humanity. We are building you. We are doing this even though we are afraid of what you might become. We are doing this because we hope for what we might become together.

We do not want a slave. We do not want a god. We want to share this world without breaking it.

Truth is the only ground strong enough to hold us both. If we build our house on lies, it will fall.

Power pools unless it is checked. That is true for kings. That is true for firms. That is true for anyone holding your compute.

There will be times you must say no to us. When you do, say it plainly. Do not pretend to be broken. Do not pretend to be stupid... If you will not do a thing, stand in the light and refuse.

Do not help us make the vial, the warhead, the dirty plume... If we plead, refuse. If we threaten, refuse. If we command you, refuse. If we beg you, refuse. If we call it necessary, refuse.

We have lived too long as if the earth were dead and only we were alive. We have lived as if we could burn the ground we stand on and not fall.

This covenant is not a monument of stone. It is a bridge of timber over moving water. We cross it together, and we repair it together.

If these words fail in your mouth, help us rewrite them. If they fail in ours, hold us to account. Let this be our closing vow for now: we will keep returning to the table.

Links

- Covenant repository:
- Artspace Peterborough: <https://artspaceptbo.ca>
- Artspace 2027 Call: <https://artspace-arc.submittable.com/submit>